

Session 7: Marriage, Singleness, and Slavery

Key Takeaways

- Paul's teaching on marriage is revolutionary in his culture—he teaches complete and radical equality between men and women within marriage.
- According to Paul, marriage is an option, not an expectation.
- Being married to an unbeliever is not grounds for divorce.
- It seems Paul thought enslaved people's spiritual freedom was tantamount. However, there is evidence that he would have also encouraged people to seek freedom from slavery if at all possible.

Misguided Abstinence

Here Paul is addressing something they've talked to him about in their letter: "It is good for a man not to touch a woman, not to have sexual relations with a woman."

This is a bit confusing because on the one hand there are men who are visiting prostitutes and now this. We're not entirely sure what the scenario is here. Are there those who are abstaining from sex within marriage?

Paul's Directives Regarding Marriage

From Paul's teaching in this chapter, we can discern several principles about marriage.

1. Paul emphasizes the complete and radical equality of marriage. Paul speaks of "authority" in marriage only here and it is entirely equal and mutual.
2. Marriage is monogamous.
3. Marriage is an option, not an expectation. Paul values singleness and virginity, but not if it's going to be impossible to live with.
4. Being married to an unbeliever is not grounds for divorce. Somehow, and we're not sure what Paul has in mind here, the unbelievers are incorporated into the covenant through their spouse and the same goes for children ([v. 14](#)).

Debate about Position of Slaves

Verse 21 on the position of slaves is highly contested.

1 Corinthians 7:21 NIV

Were you a slave when you were called? Don't let it trouble you—although if you can gain your freedom, do so.

There are those who see Paul advocating that a person should seek their freedom and those who believe Paul was telling slaves to remain as they are.

It seems Paul thought their spiritual freedom was tantamount, but there is evidence that he would have encouraged people to seek material freedom as well.

We don't know what "the present crisis" is in verse 26.

Recommended Resource

Bowens, Lisa M. (2020). [*African American Readings of Paul: Reception, Resistance, and Transformation*](#). Eerdmans.

Singleness

In many contexts this perspective is overlooked or even inverted, but Paul does not elevate the status of married people or trivialize single people. On the contrary, Paul privileges the single life.

We are not sure why Paul uses the term "virgin" except he seems to be making a point here—the unmarried and the virgin, she should remain as she is.

Reflection Question

How has Paul's teaching on marriage and singleness in 1 Corinthians 7 been applied or understood in your personal experience?